

World in Brief: Wildfires rage in France and Spain; Indian protests force resignation



Photograph: Getty Images

Wildfires forced more than 300,000 people to flee their homes in France and Spain. One man died in the Spanish region of Valencia. Blazes spread to the suburbs of the French city of Bordeaux. France's prime minister, Sébastien Lecornu, said wildfires "have reached a level that has never been seen before". Spain declared its first national emergency over a wildfire.

Protesters danced and chanted in the streets of Delhi after **India's** education minister [resigned](#). Led by a group called the Cockroach Janta Party (after a judge called unemployed youths "cockroaches"), they were [angry](#) about the leaking of important exam papers and the lack of jobs. Few had expected the government to yield. But protest leaders said they would now end their demonstrations and go home.

A car ploughed into a crowd at a gay pride event in **Berlin**, killing at least one person and injuring 16 others. Police are hunting for the driver, whom they suspect has links to "the Islamist scene". Kai Wegner, the city's mayor, described the incident as "an attack on our free and open society". Germany has seen several attacks on crowds using vehicles in recent years.

Iran said a **Ukrainian** attack on an Iranian merchant ship in the Caspian Sea killed one sailor and injured another. It urged European countries to hold Ukraine accountable in order to stop the war from widening. Meanwhile Iran-backed Houthis struck Saudi oil sites along the Red Sea coast. The attacks came during a pause in [strikes](#) between America and Iran, after 13 nights of escalating assaults.

Flávio Bolsonaro, son of Brazil's former president Jair Bolsonaro, announced that he will run in Brazil's presidential election in October. Javier Milei and Binyamin Netanyahu, the leaders of Argentina and Israel, have endorsed his candidacy. "Bolsonaro's blood flows here," the senator said. His father was sentenced to 27 years in prison for trying to overthrow Brazilian democracy.

Volodymyr Zelensky, Ukraine's president, said that **Russia** wants North Korea to send 30,000 more soldiers to fight its war on his country, and is preparing for their arrival. Separately, Russia will maintain a ban on petrol exports until 2026 and is considering extending a diesel export ban for another month. Ukrainian drone attacks on refineries have caused fuel shortages and [queues at petrol stations](#).

An intern at NATO's military headquarters in Belgium was arrested for **spying**. Belgian authorities said the woman is a Canadian national of Chinese origin, but did not say for whom she is accused of snooping. In 2021 NATO expelled eight people it accused of spying as part of a Russian delegation to the alliance, causing Russia to suspend its diplomatic mission.

Word of the week: Pix, the name of Brazil's much-loved payments system. [Our story explains](#) why it has drawn Donald Trump's ire.

Europe's brutal summer is about to get even worse



Photograph: Getty Images

The EU's third [record-breaking heatwave](#) of the year is on the way. Forecasts show parts of France surpassing 40°C once more; Spain may reach 47°C, further feeding the enormous wildfires that are blazing.

That will mean, again, thousands of extra deaths. Many could have been averted. Europe is temperate and rich. But the continent has 36% of the world's heat-related deaths, with just a tenth of its population. A major reason is Europeans' [aversion to air-conditioning](#). No other technology has a better record of saving lives: mass adoption of AC has reduced the average American's risk of dying on very hot days by 75%, for example. Yet just 23% of European households own a unit.

Politically, the topic is getting hotter. France's hard-right recently began demanding mandatory AC in public spaces; the left-wing maintains that is planetary self-harm. While they squabble, the public is shopping. Chinese AC exports to the EU have risen by 43% this summer.

A Catholic schism on Stronsay



Photograph: papastronsay

Not much usually happens on Papa Stronsay. But on Saturday the tiny, mostly uninhabited Scottish island saw its first revolution. A group of renegade monks, the Sons of the Most Holy Redeemer, consecrated a bishop there in defiance of the Roman Catholic church. That could trigger the church's second schism in a month: on July 2nd Pope Leo excommunicated all 600,000 members of the Society of Saint Paul X (SSPX) after they illicitly consecrated four bishops.

Such defiance hints at growing unrest among Catholic traditionalists. The Scottish monks and the SSPX reject Vatican II, a council which partly modernised the church in the 1960s, by ditching the Latin mass, for example. The SSPX has ties to European lawmakers, such as Maximilian Krah of the hard-right [Alternative for Germany party](#), and promotes similar theology to groups like the Napa Institute, which has hosted J.D. Vance, America's vice-president (and a convert to Catholicism). The rifts are small (there are 1.4bn Catholics globally), but significant.

A Victorian artist's life on display

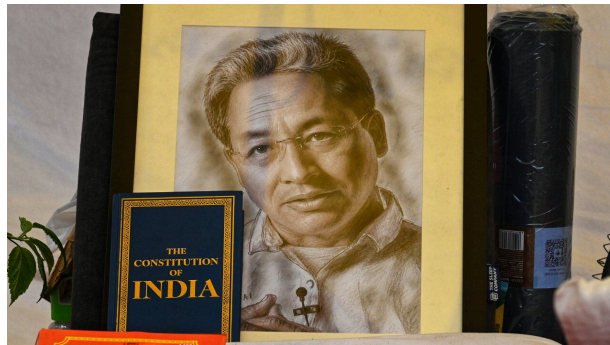


Photograph: Musee de Louvre

In the late nineteenth century, Britain devoured the mythic and supernatural. The Golden Age of Illustration produced artists like Aubrey Beardsley, whose drawings brought [Oscar Wilde's](#) "Salome" to life, and later Arthur Rackham, who created images for Lewis Carroll's "Alice's Adventures in Wonderland". Richard Dadd is less remembered but was arguably even more influential. This weekend the Royal Academy in London opens the first major exhibition of the painter's work in five decades.

Dadd began his career painting Shakespearean fairies. But after a trip to the Mediterranean he began experiencing delusions, which culminated in him killing his father, whom he mistook for the devil. He was locked up for criminal insanity from his 20s until he died, aged 68. He painted his magnum opus, "The Fairy Feller's Master-Stroke", while confined in asylums. The piece inspired a song by Queen, a rock band, in the 1970s, helping to revive his reputation after a century of obscurity. This new exhibition, which looks obliquely at mental illness, promises to do so once again.

Sonam Wangchuk, India's hunger-striker in chief



Photograph: Getty Images

Since [Mahatma Gandhi's](#) hunger strikes more than a century ago, Indians have routinely fasted as an act of protest. So frequently has this tool been wielded that the state—and indeed many Indians—have grown inured to it. So when Sonam Wangchuk began a fast in Delhi last month, demanding the resignation of India's education minister over [a series of exam-related scandals](#), few expected much to come of it.

Over the past week, India has been rocked by its biggest protests in years. Mr Wangchuk was a catalyst. The activist allied himself with the Cockroach Janta Party, a youth-protest group. For 20 days the 59-year-old, calling himself an “honorary cockroach”, wasted away. On July 18th police whisked him to a public hospital.

Their heavy-handed intervention infuriated the CJP's supporters. Two days later tens of thousands of youngsters began a march on Parliament; they were met with tear-gas and batons. Mr Wangchuk kept fasting through the chaos. Only on Friday did he finally break his fast, after receiving assurances from the government that the protesters would not be punished. The CJP welcomed his decision, but vowed to keep fighting until their main demand—the education minister's resignation—is met.

Mr Wangchuk has clashed with India's ruling Bharatiya Janata Party before. For years he has fought for statehood for Ladakh, his native Himalayan territory, which is administered directly from Delhi. That campaign included a 21-day hunger strike and his detention by police in 2024.

Yet Mr Wangchuk's life is defined less by political activism than his work on education reform. Raised in a remote village, he did not enter a classroom until he was nine. When he did, at a school in the biggest city in the region, he struggled because lessons were in Urdu, not his native Ladakhi. The experience convinced him that India's education system needed fixing.

Along with his brothers and friends, he formed a non-profit organisation focused on improving Ladakh's education system. Later he launched Operation New Hope, a grassroots programme that transformed the territory's government schools by giving local communities more authority. He trained as an engineer, which helped him create a series of innovations designed for life in the high Himalayas, including an ice stupa that stores winter meltwater during parched summers.

His exploits were deemed heroic enough even for Bollywood. Mr Wangchuk supposedly inspired the lead character in a hit from 2009 about India's flawed education system. He has long downplayed the connection. But through his role in the protests, he has emerged as a real-life hero for many. Indians concerned about the state of their country's democracy look to him and his fellow cockroaches for hope.

Mini crossword

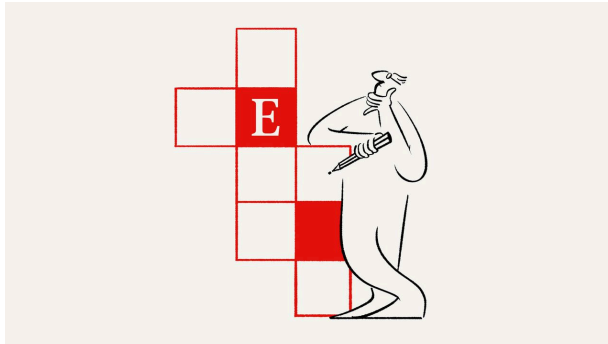


Illustration: The Economist

We publish a new interactive edition of our crossword daily, allowing you to enter and check the answers and see explanations. Try it [here](#). Or, if you prefer, use the clues below.

There are two sets of clues, one for seasoned cruciverbalists and the other for less experienced solvers. Both give the same answers.

Cryptic clues

1 across - A student tradition: drop cat. It adds up! (6)

2 across - Kudu lost bug, adopted daughter, ran off (6)

3 across - Unable to disperse dust cloud (6)

1 down - A willing but heartless chap conquered headless Greek king (9)

Straight clues

1 across - Ancient sort of calculator (6)

2 across - Ran away to marry (6)

3 across - Cloud of dust and gas (6)

1 down - Mythological Greek king (9)

The winners of this week's quiz



Illustration: Sandra Navarro

Thank you to everyone who took part in this week's quiz. The winners, chosen at random, were:

Jason Crider, Naperville, Illinois, America

Richard Small, Johannesburg, South Africa

Alison Wiebalck, Zurich, Switzerland

They all gave the correct answers of: shampoo, The Bangles, Loot, cot and dinghy. The theme is that they are all English words that derive from Hindi or other Indian languages.

The questions were:

Monday: Head & Shoulders is the best selling brand of which type of household product?

Tuesday: Which all-female rock group had hits such as “Walk Like An Egyptian” and “Manic Monday”?

Wednesday: Which Joe Orton play features the corrupt policeman Inspector Truscott?

Thursday: What is the common British term for a bed surrounded by bars and designed for a baby or small child?

Friday: The ILCA 7, ILCA 6 and Mixed 470 are Olympic categories for racing which kind of boat?

*Common sense in an uncommon
degree is what the world calls
wisdom.*

Samuel Taylor Coleridge